

openoffice.org/index.html. It is available as a .tz archive from which you can install the suite (for details on installing applications on Linux, refer to the chapter on System Maintenance). The file size is about 100 MB for the latest 2.01 release. If you are on dial-up, find a friend who has broadband!

Open Office is available for Windows as well! So even if you are using two OSes, you can have compatibility with office documents.

5.3 The GIMP

In an earlier section, we already spoke about this cool tool. If a free software does the same thing as one of the most expensive imaging software, it merits more than a mention here! And yes, in case you don't take to Linux, The GIMP is available for Windows as well! It's not only free, but also open source. Could it get any better?

The GIMP is written and developed under X11 on UNIX platforms, but the same code also runs on Windows and Mac OS X. It is designed to be easily augmented with plug-ins and extensions to do more than what it already does. There are over a hundred plug-ins available.

The basic painting / colouring tools include all the standard ones—Brush, Air brush, Pencil, Clone and also custom brushes and patterns. There is a powerful gradient editor and blend tool. For serious graphics editors, there is a surprise in store: unlike Photoshop, The GIMP does not place any restrictions on file size. Also, any number of images can be open at the same time, so long as there is enough RAM!

Have you done a lot of changes to an image or document only to realize you need to undo all of them, but you can't go beyond a certain point? The GIMP allows unlimited Undo / Redo options!